his own ‘loyalty to Central Asian political traditions with Akbar’s neglect’. During and after the Uzbek disturbances in the 1560s, Hakim offered Kabul as ‘a safe haven for Akbar’s enemies’, positioning himself as the protector of defeated refugees returning home, and also as a king in the style they remembered with such nostalgia, not an absolute monarch but ‘a primus inter pares – or first among equals’.

Akbar – ‘the greater’ – had never had much use for this old model. Thus, when the emperor marched out of Fatehpur in February to teach Hakim a lesson, he had seven groups of high-ranking mansabdars – or amirs – leading the various battalions of his army. This was to symbolize and sustain a protocol that Akbar had invented soon after he promulgated his mansabdari reforms in 1575. By the emperor’s orders, seven groups of amirs were assigned seven watches – each group to guard the emperor for a full twenty-four hours once a week.

For anyone watching to see if their stubborn emperor was having second thoughts about his style of rule for fear of Hakim’s appeal to the outraged warlords in the east, the message was clear. Akbar’s nobility stood in his service; they should not dream of stepping into his shoes.

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A year had passed since news of the Bengal insurrection reached his court, and although Akbar had spared neither resources nor men in crushing the rebellion, he had shown no sign of undoing the policies and actions that led to it: the consolidation of political and financial power in the emperor’s hands, the expansion of his social, moral, even religious authority, and the increasing diversity of his court and his beliefs. In fact, news of Bengal had arrived in the very month that a much-anticipated set of fresh debaters reached Akbar’s controversial Ibadat Khana. These were three Jesuit priests – a sensitive, self-flagellating Rudolf Aquaviva, his mind inclined towards martyrdom; the more genial Antonio Monserrate, who later wrote an account of their journey; and Francis Henriquez, a Persian convert and interpreter for his colleagues. The three men travelled from Goa to the Mughal court at Akbar’s express invitation, with a clear mission: to convert the emperor to Christianity.

They had some reason to believe they might succeed. ‘Royal converts were not unknown in the Indies’, writes a colonial historian. Kings in the